Alice’s Adventures in Wonderland

A simplified retelling

Original story by Lewis Carroll

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

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1. Down the rabbit hole

Alice was sitting beside her sister when a White Rabbit hurried past. A talking rabbit was unusual, but a rabbit checking a pocket watch was impossible to ignore. Alice followed him into a hole and fell a very long way.

She landed safely in a hall of locked doors. A small golden key opened a tiny door onto a beautiful garden, but Alice was much too large to enter.

A bottle labelled “Drink me” made her shrink. Now she could fit through the door, but she had left the key on a table she could no longer reach. Eating a cake made her grow enormous again.

Frustration brought tears. Soon she shrank once more and found herself swimming in the pool she had cried. Nothing remained the right size for long, including her confidence that she understood what was happening.

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2. A race with no clear winner

In the pool, Alice met a Mouse and other creatures. Her attempts at conversation went badly when she mentioned her cat, Dinah. She forgot that a story pleasing to a girl might frighten a mouse.

To dry themselves, the animals held a race with no clear course or finishing point. When it ended, everyone was declared a winner and everyone required a prize. Alice supplied what she had in her pockets.

Later, the White Rabbit mistook her for his servant and sent her to fetch his things. Inside his house, she drank from another bottle and grew until she filled the room. The animals outside tried various ways to remove her.

When thrown pebbles became little cakes, she ate one, shrank and escaped. Size seemed to offer power one moment and become a trap the next.

Alice wanted to find the garden. First, she needed some control over her own height.

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3. Who are you?

A Caterpillar sat on a mushroom and asked Alice who she was. She found the question unexpectedly difficult. She had changed so many times that she no longer felt entirely certain.

His advice was not especially comforting, but it was useful. Different sides of the mushroom would make her grow or shrink. After several awkward experiments, Alice learned to change her size more deliberately.

She reached the Duchess’s house, where pepper filled the air and everyone seemed angry. A cook threw things while the Duchess held a crying baby. Alice took the baby outside, hoping to protect it, and discovered that it was turning into a pig.

The Cheshire Cat appeared and disappeared in a nearby tree. Alice asked which way she should go. The Cat pointed out that the answer depended on where she wanted to arrive.

In a place full of confusing directions, it was an irritatingly reasonable observation.

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4. Tea without an ending

Alice joined the March Hare, the Hatter and the Dormouse at a tea table. They told her there was no room, although there was plenty. The conversation moved through riddles, insults and explanations that answered very little.

The Hatter described a quarrel with Time. For them, it was always tea-time. They moved around the table instead of washing the cups and beginning again properly.

Alice tried to apply the rules of polite conversation, but the others used words in ways that defeated every attempt at clarity. Eventually, she left.

She found another entrance into the hall, adjusted her size and finally reached the garden. There, three gardeners were painting white roses red because they had planted the wrong kind. They feared what the Queen would do when she discovered the mistake.

The beautiful destination had its own problems. Arriving had not ended the confusion.

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5. The Queen’s croquet ground

The Queen of Hearts arrived with a grand procession and immediately began ordering executions. Her favourite response to inconvenience was to demand that someone lose their head.

Alice joined a croquet game played with live flamingos as mallets and hedgehogs as balls. Soldiers bent into hoops, then moved away when they felt like it. A game with such equipment could not remain orderly.

The Cheshire Cat appeared as a head without a body, causing an argument about whether it could be beheaded. The Queen gave orders, but even her servants could not agree on what those orders meant.

The Duchess returned and tried to attach a moral lesson to almost everything. Then Alice was introduced to the Gryphon and the Mock Turtle. They described an absurd education and performed a dance called the Lobster Quadrille.

Alice listened, asked questions and found that even familiar school subjects could become strange when words were shifted slightly out of place.

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6. The trial

A call announced a trial: the Knave of Hearts was accused of stealing the Queen’s tarts. Alice went to watch.

The King acted as judge. The jury wrote things down before there was anything useful to record. Witnesses offered confused evidence. A poem was treated as important even though nobody could explain how it proved the case.

Alice began growing again. This time, the change came with a stronger willingness to question what she heard. When a new rule was invented to remove her, she pointed out that it was not part of any fair procedure.

The Queen wanted the sentence before the verdict. Alice refused to accept it. She told the court that its members were only a pack of cards.

They rose into the air and flew towards her. She tried to beat them away—and woke beside her sister on the riverbank.

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7. Back beside the river

Leaves were falling onto Alice’s face. The strange court, the changing sizes and the impossible conversations had belonged to a dream.

She told her sister what she remembered, then ran off to tea. Her sister remained by the river, imagining the creatures and wondering about Alice’s future.

The dream had been nonsense, but it had also made familiar things look unusual: rules, lessons, manners and the confidence with which adults gave instructions. Alice had begun by trying to obey a world she did not understand. By the end, she could recognise that an order did not become sensible merely because somebody shouted it.

For a while, her sister imagined the riverbank filled with Wonderland’s voices. Then ordinary sounds returned, carrying something of the dream’s curiosity with them.

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Words to keep

Curiosity — a desire to know or discover something. Curiosity led Alice after the Rabbit.

Absurd — so unreasonable or illogical that it seems ridiculous. The croquet game was absurd.

Riddle — a puzzling question or description. The Hatter offered a riddle without a useful answer.

Evidence — information used to establish what happened. The court handled its evidence badly.

Verdict — a court’s decision about guilt. The Queen wanted a sentence before the verdict.

Procedure — an agreed way of doing something. Alice questioned the court’s procedure.

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A question to carry with you

Which rule in Wonderland is hardest to accept? How would you explain the problem to someone who insists that it is perfectly sensible?

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